

Sonos Arc Ultra + Sub 4

Soundbar that wants to be your theatre

I 'll say this upfront: the Sonos Arc Ultra is the first soundbar I've used that actually made me forget I was listening to a soundbar. Not because it tricked me into thinking I had speakers in my ceiling, but because it pulled me into movies and music without me overthinking where the sound was coming from.

The Arc Ultra is Sonos doing what Sonos does best: making tech that feels like furniture. It's long at 46 inches, but the curves, matte finish and wrap-around grille give it the kind of elegance that blends into a living room. It looks equally good under a 65-inch OLED or mounted cleanly to the wall, and unless your setup is really compact, it doesn't feel oversized.

On paper, Sonos has gone from 11 drivers in the original Arc to 14 drivers in the Ultra, laid out for a 9.1.4 Dolby Atmos configuration. That means you're getting seven tweeters, six midrange woofers, and one of their new "Sound Motion" compact woofers that's supposedly going to displace more air than what its size suggests.

THE SOUND

Here's where it gets interesting. Alone, the Arc Ultra produces bass that the old Arc could never dream of. There's actual weight to explosions and music has a satisfying fullness around the upper bass (think 250 Hz and up). Watching the sandworm scenes or the ornithopter take-off sequences in *Dune* actually brought about the layered atmosphere in the foreground, and even the thudding impacts of Bane's underground sewer fight in *The Dark Knight Rises* felt more atmospheric.



MUSIC PLAYBACK

Switching to music tends to expose a soundbar's limits faster than movies. But the Arc Ultra shows off what Sonos has been building toward so far.

With Dream Theater's *Pull Me Under*, the sheer density of the mix didn't collapse into a wall of noise. Guitars, keys and drums all had their own space and you could follow each layer without it smearing together, filling the room with the kind of warmth you only get when a system handles separation properly.

Adele's *Hello* showed off the Arc Ultra's vocal clarity. Her voice came through forward and intimate, slightly bright at times, but never in that fatiguing way that makes you dial the volume down.

For bass sharpness, Boom by Tiesto was a great test. The bassline had just the right amount of snap and funk, punchy enough to get your foot tapping but also restrained well enough not to bleed into the mids.

Metal is usually brutal on soundbars, but Selkies from *Between the Buried*

and *Me* was surprisingly listenable. The Arc Ultra managed to keep the cymbals crisp, the guitars heavy, and the bass grounded, without letting the whole thing turn into distortion soup.

Detail retrieval really stood out with Pink Floyd's *Shine On* and Björk's *Hunter*. Instruments floated with precision across the soundstage. But not everything was perfect. The Arc Ultra doesn't give you the "shake the room, feel it in your ribcage" bass. Push its bass slider to max, and instead of earth-shattering lows, you just end up with really boomy mids.

Which is where the Sub 4 enters the picture.

SUB 4: A NECESSARY PARTNER

The Sub 4 looks like the Sonos subwoofer we've known for years: a clean, sculptural rectangle with that iconic cut-out it has in the middle. It now comes in a matte finish, and you can stand it up, lay it flat, or hide it under your couch. It's not a radical redesign, but under the hood, it's been upgraded with more processing power, new Wi-Fi radios, and dual elliptical 5 x 8 - inch woofers that face inward to cancel out any distortion.

Once you pair it with the Arc Ultra, you immediately get that missing low-end heft. The sub-bass effects in the opening flight test scene in *Top Gun*: *Maverick* felt present and physical, and the gunfire in *The Matrix* lobby scene was punchy and percussive. The best part is that you can dial the Sub's output to your taste for more rumble.

Can you live without the Sub 4? Yes, the Arc Ultra alone is already miles ahead of TV speakers and even many standalone soundbars. But if you're spending nearly Rs 1 lakh on the Arc Ultra (Rs 99,999), chances are you want the full cinematic punch. And the Sub 4 (Rs 84,999) is the piece of the puzzle that completes that picture.

EVERYDAY USE

This isn't just about movies. The Arc